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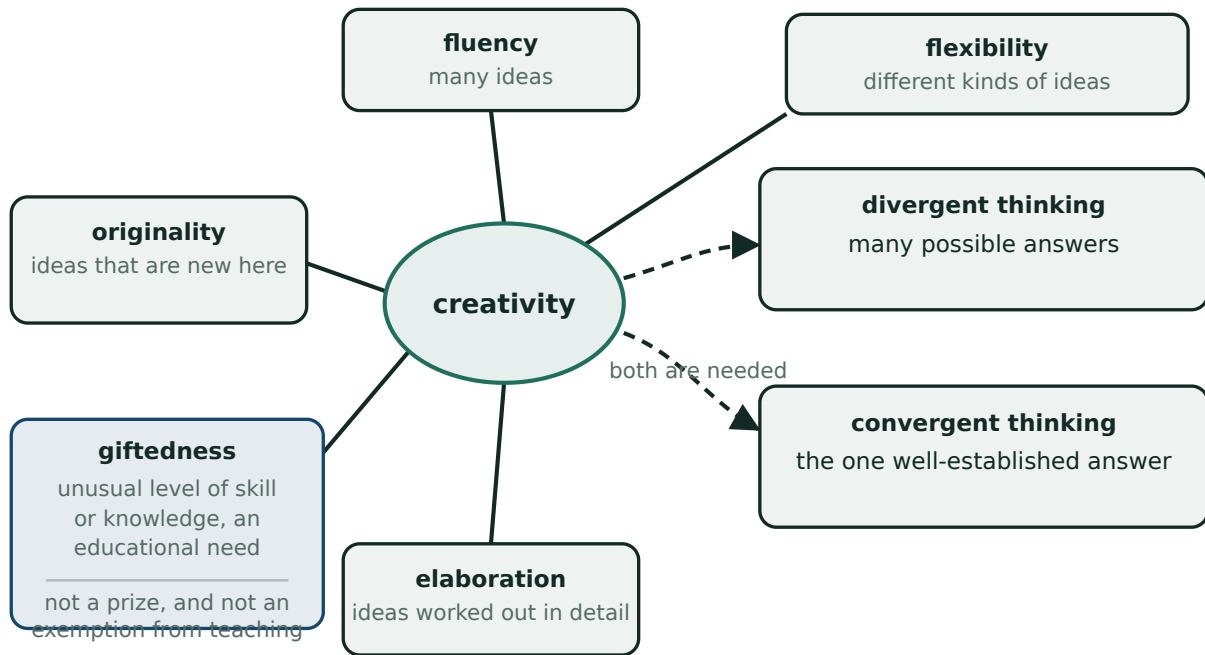
Topic 5.2 - Creativity and giftedness

A real classroom situation

Two Urdu essays arrive on the same topic, "my village". The first reuses the phrases every essay on this topic has reused for a decade: the green fields, the simple people, the fresh air. It is correct, complete, and could have been written by anyone. The second begins with the bus that no longer stops at the village, and builds the whole village around what that absence changed.

The first essay earns more marks under the usual rules - no errors, all parts present. The second is the creative one, and the way marks are given has no box for what it did. Meanwhile, at the back of the same class, a pupil finished the work twenty minutes ago and is now disturbing his neighbours, and has been doing exactly this since March.

Creativity: observable parts, thinking modes and educational need



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Explanation

Creativity: what it is and how classrooms grow it

"Creativity is the ability to generate, create, or discover new ideas, solutions, and possibilities" (Spielman, Jenkins & Lovett, 2020). The definition's value for a teacher is that it makes creativity **observable** - not a mysterious gift but a set of moves that can be counted, named and practised.

Four parts are usually distinguished. **Fluency**: how many ideas - the pupil who lists seventeen uses for a brick. **Flexibility**: how many kinds of idea - the same pupil's list includes building, a paperweight, a story prop and a boundary marker. **Originality**: how new the ideas are in this room - the bus that no longer stops. **Elaboration**: how far an idea is worked out - the village built around the absent bus.

Behind the parts sit the two thinking modes of Unit 4, now with names.

Divergent thinking "allows an individual to arrive at unique, multiple solutions to a given problem"; **convergent thinking** "describes the ability to provide a

correct or well-established answer or solution" (Spielman, Jenkins & Lovett, 2020). Creativity needs both: the divergent flood, then the convergent choice. A school that examines only convergent thinking - one right answer, found fast - trains half the pair and calls the other half misbehaviour.

The classroom conditions that grow the observable parts are ordinary and cheap: questions with more than one defensible answer; time to generate before anyone evaluates (the flood before the choice); wrong answers safe in public, because originality is a species of risk-taking; and real audiences - a poem read to the class, a poster that actually hangs - because elaboration is effort, and effort needs a reason.

The misconception to clear now. "Creativity is only for art lessons." The essay's absent bus is creative writing, but so is the mathematics pupil's unrequested second method, the science pupil who tests the control twice, and Kiran's wire-diagnosis from Topic 5.1. Creativity is a property of thinking, not of subjects, and every subject's way of giving marks either has a box for it or trains it out.

Giftedness: recognizing and teaching gifted learners

The guide pairs creativity with giftedness, and the pairing is deliberate: both are abilities the standard examination undersamples.

Giftedness means an unusual level of skill or knowledge in some domain. The traditional reading was narrow - unusually high verbal and test performance - and the modern reading is wider, "unusual talents in a range of activities", which is why educators often say "gifted and talented" (Seifert & Sutton, 2009). The qualities observed are consistent: such pupils "learn more quickly and independently than most students their own age", often show advanced language, are strongly motivated by challenge, and hold themselves to high standards (Seifert & Sutton, 2009).

Two facts carry the classroom weight. First, gifted pupils "are not necessarily awkward socially, less healthy, or narrow in their interests - in fact, quite the contrary", and they come from all economic and cultural groups (Seifert & Sutton, 2009). The stereotype of the gifted misfit is a story, and a harmful one: it tells a school to look for giftedness only in pupils who look a particular way.

Second, and harder: gifted pupils **languish without accommodation**.

"Without accommodation to their unusual level of skill or knowledge, students who are gifted or talented can become bored by school, and eventually the boredom can even turn into behavior problems" (Seifert & Sutton, 2009). The pupil who finished twenty minutes ago is not a discipline case; he is an unmet educational need wearing a discipline case's clothes. The support that fits is a mixture of challenge and structure: real problems rather than more worksheets, some say in what is studied, and expectations kept high - enrichment rather than mere acceleration, which only moves the boredom forward a year.

what you see	the common reading	what this topic suggests
the essay that reuses memorised phrases	earns the top mark	Add a box for originality: what here could not have been written by anyone.
the pupil who finishes early and disturbs others	a discipline case	An unmet need: real problems, not more worksheets.
the pupil who asks a question the textbook does not answer	wasting time	Divergent thinking doing its job: welcome it, then choose.
the gifted pupil, also sociable and sporty	does not fit the stereotype	The stereotype is the defect: look in every group.

Read each observation before applying a label.

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Activity: Marking for originality

In pairs, about 20 minutes.

Take the two "my village" essays as described (write each in five lines if you have not read them).

1. Mark both under the usual scheme: content, accuracy, organisation, presentation.

2. Now add a fifth box: originality - "what in this essay could not have been written by anyone?" Mark both again.
3. Compare the two orderings. Decide together what the fifth box should be worth, and defend the weight you give it.

Then: design the ten-minute task you would set the whole class tomorrow that has more than one defensible answer - the task whose marking needs the fifth box.

Check your understanding

1. Define creativity in one sentence, and name its four observable parts.
(Remember)
2. Explain divergent and convergent thinking with one classroom example of each. *(Understand)*
3. Name three classroom conditions that grow creativity, and say which part each grows. *(Apply)*
4. State the two facts about gifted pupils that carry the classroom weight, in two sentences. *(Understand)*
5. The early finisher is disturbing the class. Give the unmet-need reading and one response that follows from it. *(Apply)*

Summary

Creativity is the ability to generate the new, and it is observable: fluency, flexibility, originality, elaboration, powered by divergent thinking and disciplined by convergent. Classrooms grow it with open questions, generation before evaluation, safe wrong answers and real audiences - and every way of giving marks either has a box for originality or trains it out. Giftedness is an unusual level of skill or knowledge, an educational need rather than a prize: gifted pupils come from every group, mostly thrive socially, and languish - into boredom and misbehaviour - without accommodation. The support is enrichment and real challenge, not more of the same worksheet.

Self-assessment checklist

Sign in to sync your ticks across devices.

- ☐ I can define creativity and name its four observable parts.
- ☐ I can explain divergent and convergent thinking with an example of each.
- ☐ I can name the classroom conditions that grow creativity and link each to a part.
- ☐ I can read the early finisher as an unmet need and name a response that follows.

Try this at your practicum school

Add the fifth box to one piece of marking this week: "what here could not have been written by anyone?" Do not change the total marks. Note what the box reveals, and what the class does when it discovers the box exists.

Summative task

Write **250-300 words** designing for the two pupils.

Design one task - any subject, any class - that serves both the pupil who finished twenty minutes ago and the pupil whose essay reuses memorised phrases. Name what each pupil needs from the task (using this topic's terms), how the task meets both needs at once, and how it would be marked. Concede the one thing the task cannot do.

Mini-rubric

Criterion	What a strong answer shows
Needs named precisely	Each pupil's need is stated in this topic's terms, not as "bored" and "weak".
One task, both needs	The design genuinely serves both, and the mechanism is explained. <i>(Create)</i>

Criterion	What a strong answer shows
Marking thought through	The way marks are given includes the fifth box or its equivalent.
Honest concession	The task's limit is named, not hidden.

Further reading

- Spielman, R., Jenkins, W., & Lovett, M. (2020). *Psychology 2e* (OpenStax), Section 7.4. CC BY-NC-SA 4.0. <https://openstax.org/books/psychology-2e/pages/7-4-what-are-intelligence-and-creativity>
- Seifert, K., & Sutton, R. (2009). *Educational Psychology* (2nd ed.), Chapters 5 and 9. University of Manitoba. CC BY. <https://open.umn.edu/opentextbooks/textbooks/educational-psychology>

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